

your parents' coverage for 18 months if your parents make the request within 60 days after they're notified that your coverage is about to lapse. You will have to pay for this coverage, but the price will probably be less than the price of a similar policy you could get on your own.

- **A group plan.** Groups get better deals than individuals. See if there's a professional association, religious organization, or any other group that will offer you coverage. The Freelancers Union ([www.freelancersunion.org](http://www.freelancersunion.org)) offers group health insurance in New York State and individual plans in thirty other states. If you're a lawyer, try your local bar association. If you're a real estate or travel agent, call your local trade association. If you're an artist, contact a community artists league. If you're currently doing temp work, look for a temp agency that offers health benefits. (Some agencies offer employees the chance to buy group coverage.)
- **Temporary coverage.** If you're out of work but seriously hunting for a job, look into a temporary insurance policy. This type of policy lasts up to a year and can be renewed once; the rules vary from state to state. After twelve months you will hopefully have found a job with health benefits. The advantage of these policies is that they're cheap. The disadvantage is that you probably won't be covered for any preexisting conditions. You should also consider a temporary policy if you start a new job and your employer requires you to be with the firm for several months before your health insurance kicks in.

Keep in mind that many insurers will take your medical condition into account when determining your premium, and they might even deny you coverage outright. (The only exceptions: New York, New Jersey, Massachusetts, Maine, and Vermont.) The healthier your lifestyle, the lower your insurance rates will be; for example, quitting smoking can cut your premiums by 10% to 15% a year. (Not to mention save your life.)